

received at closing to pay for a new roof. Their \$10,000 cushion gives them a sense of security, and they even have to dip into it when a small problem arises with their house's plumbing—but when all is said and done, Alex and Shelby are completely financially secure.

Six years down the road, Alex and Shelby decide it's time to move into a bigger place. Not only has their home appreciated due to a steady increase in home prices in their neighborhood, but they added value by updating the kitchen and landscaping. They're sitting on a huge chunk of appreciation—enough to offset the transaction costs of buying and selling this house! Though they had plans to hang on to this home as a rental after moving out, they don't really need to take that route. Instead, they sell this home to move on to the next.

Their first home purchase served them well. Because of their brilliant preparation, there was no tossing and turning at night about their mortgage payments, no sense of desperation when that sewer expense popped up, and never a single concern that they wouldn't be able to afford their home. By resisting the allure of the American dream, Alex and Shelby gave up on the house on a hill and instead achieved something much, much greater: financial security, flexibility, and peace of mind.

Oh, and they were still able to give their dog a lovely yard and listen to Nickelback at full blast without anyone else's judgment. It's really a win-win for everyone.